

A passing Mumbai local train with two young people standing at the door, lost in thought. Above, a foot overbridge crowded with grey figures rushing to or from work, with a skyscraper looming in the background. 'Aspire' (2024) captures the essence of Maximum City, where in the face of daily drudgery, people dream of a better life. In his just-concluded solo exhibition at Delhi's Vadehra Art Gallery—which will travel to other Indian cities—Sudhir Patwardhan's tremendous empathy for the subaltern middle class is evident. Via *Cities: Built, Broken*, the veteran artist continues to tell stories of his protagonists rooted to their locales through varying intensities of emotion.

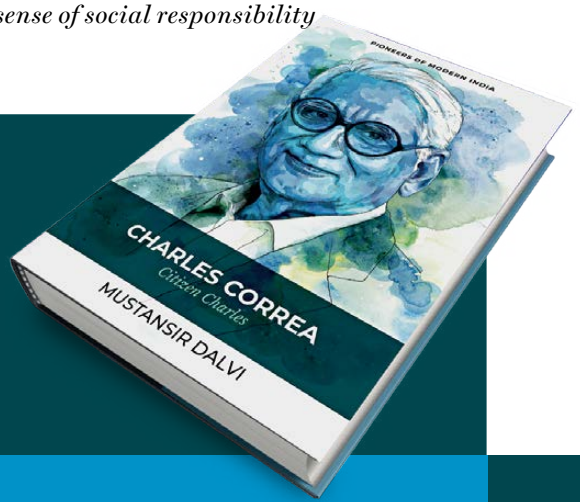
Born in Pune in 1949, Patwardhan graduated in medicine from the Armed Forces Medical College in 1972, and practised as a radiologist in Thane from 1975 to 2005. The self-taught artist is recognised as one of India's first postmodern painters, and has been illustrating evocative cityscapes and depictions of Mumbai's working classes since the 1970s. "When I first came to (then) Bombay in the '70s, the working class movement was strong, with many rallies, morchas and strikes, and my work reflected that. Then we moved to Thane, and I saw the expansion of the city margins, how nature was being devoured. My work in the '90s reflected that. Lately, an infrastructure boom is reshaping the city.... To what extent this will improve the life for the ordinary citizen remains to be seen, and this is a subject for exploration in my new work," says Patwardhan.

The exhibition featured about 65 recent works, including large and small canvases as well as drawings across various scales. In the exhibition essay, art critic and curator Gayatri Sinha writes: "Sudhir Patwardhan's vision of Mumbai as spatial metaphor appears to have come full circle. The vast panoramas of the city under construction that he painted in the 1980s and 1990s, of structures rising from acres of muddy land, now return in a Kafkaesque horror of overgrown metal and concrete." The early influences of Cézanne are also evident in Patwardhan's visualisation of the human figure, including its mental distortions and physical vagaries. For example, in 'Under a Clear Blue Sky' (2024), a Muslim man stands before a partially

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